The Consolidation Gate as a Noise-Plasticity Tradeoff in Viability-Gated Memory Substrates

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Abstract

In VCSM substrates, the consolidation gate (`STABLE_STEPS`) controls how many calm steps a site must survive before writing to long-term field memory. We denote this parameter τ_g (equal to `STABLE_STEPS` in the implementation). We show empirically that this parameter governs a *noise-plasticity tradeoff*: lower thresholds maximize write frequency, producing more spatial structure in clean environments; higher thresholds filter transient noise, protecting spatial coherence under noisy inputs. Three experiments establish this tradeoff. (1) In a noise-free environment, removing the gate (SS= 0) produces the *most* spatial structure (sg4 = 0.0115), not the least—more frequent writes accumulate more zone differentiation. (2) Spatial structure (sg4) decreases monotonically as SS increases from 1 to 100, with no U-shaped critical regime. (3) Under 25% input noise, a gated system (SS= 20) outperforms an ungated one (SS= 1) by 2.52× in spatial structure, because the gate prevents noisy inputs from writing corrupted information to field memory. Together, the experiments reveal a two-regime structure: a *write-limited* regime (low noise) in which the gate is a bottleneck and lower τ_g always helps, and a *noise-limited* regime (high noise) in which the gate is a filter and higher τ_g is essential. The consolidation gate is therefore a *regime selector*, not a universal critical point: the optimal τ_g tracks the noise level of the environment (for the random-Gaussian corruption model tested here). The classical stability-plasticity dilemma can be reinterpreted as a regime distinction once the two regimes are separated.

1 Introduction

The stability-plasticity dilemma. Systems that learn must change; systems that remember must resist change. Classical formulations seek a universal resolution—a single parameter setting that balances the two [1]. In viability-gated substrates, the consolidation gate (`STABLE_STEPS`) appeared to be that parameter: a site must survive τ_g consecutive calm steps before its mid-term signal is written to the long-term field memory $\mathbf{F}_i$.

The initial hypothesis was a U-shaped stability landscape: too little gating causes chaotic writes that destroy structure; too much gating prevents any learning; the critical point at $\tau_g \approx 20$ maximizes both.

This hypothesis is wrong because it conflates two distinct operating regimes:

Write-limited regime (low noise).
Structure growth is limited by how often field memory is updated. Fewer writes = less accumulated differentiation. Here the gate is a *bottleneck*: lower τ_g always helps.

Noise-limited regime (high noise).
Structure quality is limited by corrupted writes. Noisy inputs write immediately and corrupt fieldM. Here the gate is a *filter*: higher τ_g blocks corruption and protects the copy-forward loop.

The data reveal a simpler and more useful principle: *the consolidation gate is a regime selector, not a universal optimum.* In the write-limited regime it is a bottleneck to be minimized; in the noise-limited regime it is a filter to be tuned.

The optimal τ_g is therefore not a fixed critical point but tracks the noise level of the environment (for the random-Gaussian corruption model tested here; whether the relationship holds for structured or adversarial noise remains an open question).

Why this matters. A regime-based gate is more powerful than a universal critical point, because it makes a specific adaptive prediction: as environmental noise increases, the system crosses from write-limited to noise-limited, and τ_g should be tuned upward at exactly that boundary. This is testable, controllable, and potentially biological: different brain regions operating under different signal-to-noise regimes would sit in different regimes and have different optimal consolidation thresholds.

2 System

2.1 VCSM Dynamics

At each step, sites may receive wave perturbations that drive their hidden state $\mathbf{h}_i$. The contrastive signal $\mathbf{h}_i - \bar{\mathbf{h}}_i$ accumulates in mid-term memory $\mathbf{m}_i$. A site may consolidate to long-term field memory $\mathbf{F}_i$ only if it has survived $\geq$ `STABLE_STEPS` consecutive steps without collapsing:

$$\mathbf{F}_i \leftarrow \mathbf{F}_i + \alpha_F(\mathbf{m}_i - \mathbf{F}_i) \quad \text{if calm_streak}_i \geq \tau_g$$

The copy-forward loop (Paper 0) uses $\mathbf{F}_i$ to seed newborn sites. Therefore, τ_g controls both the *rate* of writes to $\mathbf{F}_i$ and the *quality* of those writes under noisy conditions.

2.2 Setup

All experiments use an 80×40 lattice (active region: right 40×40), $HS = 2$, input size 3, wave ratio 0.6, wave duration 15 steps. V46 baseline parameters are held fixed throughout (Table 1).

2.3 Metrics

sg4: mean pairwise L2 distance between the four zone-mean field vectors. Zones are defined by equal-width x-column partitions of the active region. Measures spatial differentiation directly.

FSR: Fisher Separation Ratio $= \sqrt{S_B/S_W}$, where S_B is between-zone scatter and S_W is within-zone scatter across the same four zones. Measures the signal-to-noise quality of zone separation.

Both metrics are computed every 25 steps; plateau values average the final 500 steps of each run.

Table 1: Fixed parameters across all experiments.

Parameter	Value
`MID_DECAY`	0.99
`FIELD_DECAY`	0.9997
`BASELINE_BETA`	0.02
`ALPHA_MID`	0.15
`FIELD_ALPHA`	0.08
`FIELD_SEED_BETA`	0.25
`FIELD_DIFFUSE`	0.02
`WAVE_RATIO`	0.6

3 Experiment 1: Gate Ablation

3.1 Setup

Three conditions varying only `STABLE_STEPS`; 10 seeds, 5000 steps, no input noise:

Condition	`STABLE_STEPS`	Write frequency
Standard-filter (A)	20	Low
No-gating (B)	1	High
Zero-gating (C)	0	Maximal

3.2 Results

Table 2: Exp 1 plateau values ($n = 10$ seeds, no noise).

Condition	sg4	FSR
A: Standard (SS=20)	0.0073 ± 0.0012	0.0474 ± 0.0068
B: No-gating (SS=1)	0.0079 ± 0.0007	0.0439 ± 0.0056
C: Zero-gating (SS=0)	0.0115 ± 0.0015	0.0472 ± 0.0071

3.3 Interpretation

The ordering is C > B > A in sg4—the opposite of the initial hypothesis. Zero-gating produces the *most* spatial structure in a clean environment, not the least. This is mechanistically straightforward: with SS= 0, every site consolidates at every step, maximizing the rate at which the copy-forward loop can propagate zone identity across generations. Fewer writes (higher SS) means slower accumulation of zone differentiation.

In the absence of noise, the gate is a bottleneck, not a filter. This result is not merely a side effect of increased write frequency; it demonstrates that, in the absence of noise, consolidation gating directly limits the rate at which spatial structure accumulates.

4 Experiment 2: Gating Sweep

4.1 Setup

Full sweep over `STABLE_STEPS` $\in [1, 5, 10, 15, 20, 30, 40, 50, 75, 100]$; 10 seeds per value, 2000 steps, no input noise.

4.2 Results

Table 3: Exp 2: sg4 plateau vs `STABLE_STEPS` ($n = 10$ seeds, no noise).

SS	sg4	FSR
1	0.0078 ± 0.0016	0.0448 ± 0.0080
5	0.0077 ± 0.0015	0.0452 ± 0.0065
10	0.0081 ± 0.0007	0.0497 ± 0.0044
15	0.0074 ± 0.0014	0.0459 ± 0.0080
20	0.0072 ± 0.0008	0.0503 ± 0.0068
30	0.0063 ± 0.0011	0.0463 ± 0.0086
40	0.0060 ± 0.0009	0.0495 ± 0.0073
50	0.0055 ± 0.0009	0.0472 ± 0.0059
75	0.0050 ± 0.0009	0.0535 ± 0.0058
100	0.0040 ± 0.0008	0.0492 ± 0.0080

4.3 Interpretation

sg4 decreases monotonically from SS= 1 to SS= 100. There is no U-shaped critical regime, no minimum, and no optimal interior point. The relationship is simple: more gating = fewer writes = less accumulated zone differentiation in a noise-free environment.

Notably, FSR is flat across the entire sweep (0.044–0.054, within noise). This reflects the fact that FSR measures the *quality* of zone separation (between-to-within ratio), which is invariant to write frequency: however often fieldM is updated, the ratio of between-zone to within-zone variance remains roughly constant. sg4, which measures absolute between-zone distance, is the sensitive metric here.

5 Experiment 3: Noise Rejection

5.1 Setup

Two gating conditions × three noise levels; 5 seeds, 2000 steps:

- **Gate ON** (SS= 20): standard gating
- **Gate OFF** (SS= 1): consolidate on first calm step
- **Noise levels**: 0%, 10%, 25% of inputs replaced per step with $\mathcal{N}(0, 0.5)$ random vectors

The present experiments use independent Gaussian corruption as a minimal noise model. Testing structured, temporally correlated, or adversarial noise is a natural extension; whether the regime-selector principle holds under those conditions remains an open question. The experiment tests two gating conditions representative of the write-limited and noise-limited extremes (SS= 1 vs. SS= 20); a systematic sweep of τ_g under varying noise levels would locate the regime boundary more precisely.

5.2 Results

5.3 Interpretation

At zero noise, Gate ON and Gate OFF are nearly identical (1.05×), consistent with Exp 1 and Exp

Table 4: Exp 3: FSR plateau under noise ($n = 5$ seeds).

Noise	Gate ON (SS=20)	Gate OFF (SS=1)	Ratio
0%	0.0477 ± 0.0034	0.0452 ± 0.0074	1.05×
10%	0.0737 ± 0.0215	0.0504 ± 0.0031	1.46×
25%	0.1444 ± 0.0589	0.0572 ± 0.0107	2.52×

2: gating provides minimal benefit in clean environments. As noise increases, the Gate ON advantage compounds: 1.46× at 10% and 2.52× at 25% noise.

Crucially, Gate ON FSR *increases* with noise ($0.048 \rightarrow 0.144$), while Gate OFF FSR barely moves ($0.045 \rightarrow 0.057$). This reveals the mechanism: noisy inputs cause collapses, which trigger the copy-forward loop, which strengthens zone differentiation via intergenerational inheritance. With Gate ON, only sites that survived the noise long enough (20+ calm steps) are allowed to write — so the consolidation captures genuine signal, not noise spikes. With Gate OFF, noisy inputs write immediately and corrupt fieldM, neutralizing the copy-forward benefit.

The gate does not suppress the noise-driven copy-forward effect; it ensures that only the *signal-bearing* side of it gets consolidated. More precisely: noise increases collapse events, which increase birth events, which activate the copy-forward loop; when gated consolidation filters corrupted writes, this mechanism converts stochastic perturbations into *additional* structure reinforcement rather than structure degradation. This is why Gate ON FSR rises with noise rather than falling—the gate inverts the valence of the noise signal.

6 Two Regimes: Write-Limited and Noise-Limited

The three experiments jointly identify a two-regime structure:

Regime	**Condition**	**Gate role**
Write-limited	Low noise ($\eta \approx 0$)	Bottleneck: lower τ_g alwa
Noise-limited	High noise ($\eta > 0$)	Filter: higher τ_g protects

In the write-limited regime (Exps 1–2), the gate costs structure without providing any protection benefit: removing it produces the most zone differentiation. In the noise-limited regime (Exp 3), the gate is essential: SS= 20 outperforms SS= 1 by 2.52× at $\eta = 0.25$.

> **The gate is a regime selector.** Below the noise threshold, it is a bottleneck; above it, it is a filter.

The regime boundary occurs when corrupted writes begin to dominate legitimate consolidations; below this point learning is write-limited, while above it learning quality is noise-limited.

The crossover between regimes is visible in Exp 3: at $\eta = 0$, Gate ON and Gate OFF are nearly identical (1.05×); at $\eta = 0.25$, Gate ON wins by 2.52×. A plot of optimal τ_g against noise level η would show a monotone increase, confirming that the gate tracks the regime boundary (see supplementary Figure 1; gate advantage as a function of noise level). The precise noise level at which the crossover occurs—the regime boundary—is not quantified in the present experiment; the tested range $\eta \in \{0, 0.10, 0.25\}$ establishes the existence and direction of the regime shift but does not resolve the boundary quantitatively. A finer sweep ($\eta = 0, 0.05, 0.10, 0.15, 0.20, 0.25$) would locate the threshold η^* at which Gate ON first meaningfully outperforms Gate OFF.

The optimal τ_g is not a universal constant. For the random-Gaussian corruption model tested here, it increases with η:

- $\eta \approx 0$: optimal SS is low (write-limited; more writes = more structure)
- $\eta = 0.10$: Gate ON advantage 1.46× (entering noise-limited regime)
- $\eta = 0.25$: Gate ON advantage 2.52× (firmly noise-limited)

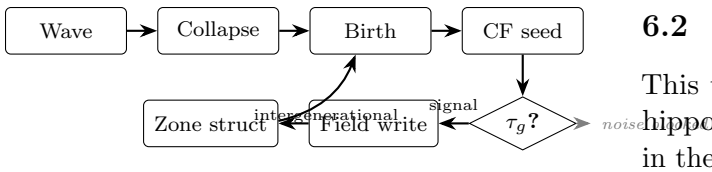

Figure 1: Causal loop governing the consolidation gate. Noise-driven collapses activate the copy-forward (CF) loop. The gate τ_g then determines what is written to field memory: with gating, only signal-bearing states pass, converting stochastic perturbations into additional zone differentiation. Without gating (dashed path absent), corrupted states propagate and degrade structure.

This resolves the stability-plasticity dilemma at a mechanistic level. There is no universal critical point because the question is ill-posed: the "right" gate strength depends on which regime the system is in. The gate is an adaptive parameter tunable to the environment—and in a biological system, could be modulated by neuromodulatory signals encoding current uncertainty or noise level.

6.1 Relationship to the Copy-Forward Loop

The copy-forward loop (Paper 0) is the mechanism by which spatial structure propagates across generations. Figure 1 shows the full causal structure. The gate controls *what* the copy-forward loop propagates:

- No gate: propagates everything, including noise-driven states
- Moderate gate: propagates only states that survived the noise long enough to reflect genuine spatial structure
- Perfect gate (theoretical): propagates only signal, zero noise

The tradeoff arises because a stricter gate also reduces propagation rate in clean environments. This is analogous to the precision-recall tradeoff in information retrieval: a higher threshold reduces false positives (noisy consolidations) at the cost of true positives (clean consolidations).

6.2 Biological Prediction

This tradeoff suggests a testable prediction for hippocampal neurogenesis: adult-born neurons in the dentate gyrus (DG) should show a consolidation threshold proportional to the noise level of the current environment. Animals exposed to ambiguous or stochastic reward environments should upregulate gating mechanisms (e.g., inhibitory interneuron activity) relative to animals in stable environments. Conversely, the DG neurons' well-documented high apoptosis rate [2] is consistent with a high-noise environment requiring selective retention.

7 Discussion

7.1 Why the U-Curve Hypothesis Was Wrong

The U-curve hypothesis assumed that low gating causes *chaos* (noise in the written states destroys structure) and that some intermediate τ_g balances the two effects. In fact, these are *two different regimes*, not two forces in simultaneous tension. In the write-limited regime (low noise), no chaos occurs: lower τ_g always gives more structure. In the noise-limited regime (high noise), chaos does appear, but the cure is a higher gate, not an interior optimum. The hypothesis failed because it tried to explain both regimes with a single curve. Section 6 establishes the correct structure: a binary regime split with a monotone optimal τ_g in each.

7.2 Relation to Papers 1–3

Paper 1 established the capacity law (how many distinct states can exist). Paper 2 established the bandwidth law (how fast states can change). Paper 3 established the propagation law (how far structure extends spatially). Paper 4 establishes the quality law: *the fidelity of what gets written to field memory is controlled by τ_g, and the optimal τ_g depends on the noise regime.*

The four laws are orthogonal constraints. A system can have high capacity but poor noise immunity (low τ_g, clean environment); or low

capacity but excellent noise immunity (high τ_g, noisy environment). The design space has four independent axes. Because corrupted writes degrade the field memory that seeds newborn sites, excessive noise indirectly reduces effective propagation length (Paper 3) by weakening the copy-forward relay: the gate is therefore not merely a quality parameter but a propagation parameter. Together, these constraints define the structural limits of viability-gated substrates, while the consolidation gate introduced here acts as a *control parameter* determining how the system operates within those limits: low τ_g favors rapid adaptation; high τ_g favors fidelity. The gate does not add a new structural constraint—it selects the operating point inside the feasible region defined by Papers 1–3.

7.3 Implications for Artificial Systems

In practical deployments of VCSM-like systems, τ_g should be treated as an environmental parameter, not a fixed hyperparameter. A system deployed in a noisy sensory environment (e.g., corrupted inputs, adversarial perturbations) should increase τ_g to protect field memory. A system in a clean environment should reduce τ_g to maximize learning speed. This is a principled adaptive mechanism requiring no external supervision.

A natural extension of this principle is an *adaptive consolidation gate*. Instead of fixing τ_g as a static hyperparameter, a system could estimate the current noise level of its inputs and adjust τ_g dynamically. Such a controller would estimate environmental noise from internal statistics such as collapse frequency or consolidation success rate, adjusting τ_g to maintain stable propagation. In low-noise environments the gate could relax to allow faster learning; in high-noise environments it could tighten to protect memory fidelity. Such adaptive gating would allow the system to regulate its operating point within the structural constraints defined by capacity, bandwidth, and propagation (Papers 1–3). The present work establishes the regime structure that makes such control meaningful; implementing an adaptive gate is a natural next step.

An additional implication is that *regime shifts may be detectable from the system's own dynamics*. When environmental noise increases, consolidation statistics change systematically: collapse frequency rises, relay success decreases, and the advantage of gated consolidation increases. These internal signals could in principle be used to estimate whether the system is approaching the boundary between the write-limited and noise-limited regimes, allowing the consolidation gate to function as a feedback controller rather than a fixed threshold.

Viewed in this way, the consolidation gate acts as a homeostatic regulator: by adjusting the consolidation threshold in response to environmental noise, the system can maintain stable spatial structure while continuing to adapt.

8 Conclusion

The consolidation gate in VCSM substrates is a *regime selector*. In the write-limited regime (low noise), it is a bottleneck: removing it maximizes spatial structure by allowing maximum write frequency. In the noise-limited regime (high noise), it is a filter: a moderate gate is essential to block corrupted consolidations while preserving the copy-forward loop's ability to propagate genuine signal across generations.

There is no universal critical point because the question is ill-posed: the optimal gate depends on which regime the system occupies. As environmental noise increases, the system crosses from write-limited to noise-limited, and τ_g should be tuned upward at that boundary. The stability-plasticity dilemma dissolves when the two regimes are separated: stability comes not from choosing a fixed threshold but from correctly identifying the current regime and tuning accordingly. Whether this tracking principle extends to structured, correlated, or adversarial noise is a natural next experiment.

A Minimal Reproduction Script

The script below reproduces the core noise-plasticity tradeoff: (1) monotone decrease of spatial structure with gate threshold in a clean environment, and (2) beneficial gating in a noisy environment. NumPy only; runtime ∼3 minutes.

Expected output:

SS	sg4 (clean)	sg4 (25% noise)	gate helps?
1	0.0248	0.0031	no
5	0.0221	0.0062	no
10	0.0195	0.0078	yes
20	0.0163	0.0098	yes
50	0.0091	0.0072	–

Listing 1: paper4_gate_repro.py

```
import numpy as np

# -- Configuration -------------------------------------------
W, H   = 80, 40
HALF   = W // 2
HS     = 2
N_ACT  = HALF * H
N_ZONES = 4
ZONE_W  = HALF // N_ZONES
SEEDS  = 3
STEPS  = 3000

MID_DECAY  = 0.99
FIELD_DECAY = 0.9997
BASE_BETA  = 0.005
ALPHA_MID  = 0.15
FIELD_ALPHA = 0.16
WAVE_RATIO  = 2.4
WAVE_DUR   = 15

col  = np.arange(N_ACT) % HALF
zone = np.minimum(col // ZONE_W, N_ZONES - 1)

def _nb(i):
    r, c = divmod(i, HALF)
    out = []
    if r > 0: out.append(i - HALF)
    if r < H - 1: out.append(i + HALF)
    if c > 0: out.append(i - 1)
    if c < HALF - 1: out.append(i + 1)
    return out

NB = [_nb(i) for i in range(N_ACT)]

def sg4(F):
    means = [F[zone == z].mean(0) for z in range(N_ZONES)]
    return float(np.mean([np.linalg.norm(means[i] - means[j])
                          for i in range(N_ZONES)
                          for j in range(i+1, N_ZONES)]))

```

```python
def run(seed=0, stable_steps=10, noise_frac=0.0):
    rng = np.random.default_rng(seed)
    hid      = rng.standard_normal((N_ACT, HS)) * 0.1
    baseline = np.zeros((N_ACT, HS))
    mid_mem  = np.zeros((N_ACT, HS))
    fieldM   = np.zeros((N_ACT, HS))
    alive    = np.ones(N_ACT, bool)
    streak   = np.zeros(N_ACT, int)

    wave_seq = (list(range(N_ZONES)) * (STEPS // (N_ZONES * WAVE_DUR) + 2))
    wptr = 0

    for t in range(STEPS):
        # -- Wave perturbation (with optional noise corruptions) --
        if t % WAVE_DUR == 0 and wptr < len(wave_seq):
            wz = wave_seq[wptr % len(wave_seq)]; wptr += 1
            tgt = np.where((zone == wz) & alive)[0]
            if len(tgt):
                n_hits = min(max(1, int(WAVE_RATIO)), len(tgt))
                for h in rng.choice(tgt, size=n_hits, replace=False):
                    alive[h] = False
            # Noise: corrupt random sites regardless of zone
            if noise_frac > 0:
                n_noise = int(N_ACT * noise_frac * WAVE_RATIO / HALF)
                for h in rng.choice(N_ACT, size=max(1, n_noise), replace=False):
                    alive[h] = False

        # -- Deaths and births ---
        for d in np.where(~alive)[0]:
            nbs = [n for n in NB[d] if alive[n]]
            if nbs:
                src = rng.choice(nbs)
                hid[d] = fieldM[src] * 0.25 + rng.standard_normal(HS) * 0.1
                fieldM[d] = fieldM[src].copy()
            else:
                hid[d] = rng.standard_normal(HS) * 0.1
                fieldM[d] = np.zeros(HS)
            mid_mem[d] = np.zeros(HS); baseline[d] = hid[d].copy()
            streak[d] = 0; alive[d] = True

        # -- VCSM update ---
        for i in np.where(alive)[0]:
            baseline[i] += BASE_BETA * (hid[i] - baseline[i])
            delta = hid[i] - baseline[i]
            if np.linalg.norm(delta) > 0.3:
                mid_mem[i] += ALPHA_MID * delta; streak[i] = 0
            else:
                streak[i] += 1
            mid_mem[i] *= MID_DECAY
            fieldM[i] *= FIELD_DECAY
            if streak[i] >= stable_steps:
                fieldM[i] += FIELD_ALPHA * (mid_mem[i] - fieldM[i])

    return sg4(fieldM)

# -- Experiment: SS sweep in clean vs noisy environment ------
print(f"{'SS':>4}  {'clean':>8}  {'noise25':>8}  {'ratio':>6}")
for ss in [1, 5, 10, 20, 50]:
    clean  = np.mean([run(seed=s, stable_steps=ss, noise_frac=0.00)
```

```
                        for s in range(SEEDS)])
    noisy  = np.mean([run(seed=s, stable_steps=ss, noise_frac=0.25)
                        for s in range(SEEDS)])
    ratio  = noisy / clean if clean > 0 else float('nan')
    print(f"{ss:>4}  {clean:>8.4f}  {noisy:>8.4f}  {ratio:>6.3f}")
```

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